Tamil Nadu
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The Festive Spirit of TAMIL NADU

With a vibrant calendar of festivals, Tamil Nadu offers travellers an opportunity to witness its glorious traditional festivities throughout the year.

Tamil Nadu is known for its rich cultural heritage and vibrant festivals, which are a huge draw for travellers. The Tamil year is a glorious string of festivities which resonate deeply with the land, its people and the rhythm of the seasons. Travellers who time their visit around one of the State's traditional festivals are in for a treat. Not only will they observe a living, ancient culture and its time-honoured rituals from close quarters but they will also depart with cherished travel memories and matching photographs.

These are some of the most iconic and popular traditional festivals of Tamil Nadu that should be on the radar of every traveller visiting the State:

PONGAL

The harvest festival of the Tamils, Pongal is a time to clean and decorate homes, prepare ritual dishes with the new rice, don new garments and spend time with family. The festival is celebrated in the middle of January every year and marks the northward movement of the Sun as well as the auspicious beginning of the Tamil month of Thai. Farmers bedeck their cattle and cultural events are held across the State. Celebrated over four days, each day of Pongal has its own significance and customs. Of course, you must try Pongal during the festival—a gruel made with the newly harvested rice, milk, and jaggery.

Jallikattu is an ancient bullfighting sport that is celebrated on the third day of Pongal in districts like Madurai, Pudukottai, Tiruchirappalli and Thanjavur. The name comes from two words, jalli (silver and gold coins) and kattu (tied). A bull is let loose among a crowd of people and whoever tames it will get the coins tied to its horn. Participants try to hold on to the animal's hump to stop it. Sometimes, they run along with the bull. Pulikulam or Kangayam is the breed of bulls used for the sport. Jallikattu is one of the highlights of cultural tourism in Tamil Nadu.

THAIPUSAM

This festival is celebrated on the first full moon day of the Tamil month of Thai (January-February) and commemorates the victory of Lord Murugan over the demon Surapadman. Lord Murugan defeats the demon with a spear given by his mother, Goddess Parvati. The festival is observed with great gusto in Murugan temples across Tamil Nadu. These include the Dhandayuthapani Swamy Temple in Palani, where the festival is celebrated over 10 days as Brahmotsavam. Thousands of pilgrims attend the ritual procession at the Subramaniya Swamy Temple in Tiruchendur. Meanwhile, float festivals are held in the temple tanks at Madurai's Meenakshi Temple and the Kapaleeshwarar Temple in Mylapore, Chennai.

CHITHIRAI FESTIVAL

It is said that a visit to Tamil Nadu is incomplete without witnessing the Chithirai Festival of Madurai. Held in mid-April in the Tamil month of Chithirai (April-May), this festival reenacts the wedding of Lord Sundareswarar (Lord Shiva) and Goddess Meenakshi and coincides with Puthandu which is the Tamil New Year. On this day Tamils greet each



Pongal Festival



Jallikattu